

The AI Side Hustle

A Plain-English Beginner's Guide to Creating and
Selling
Digital Products with AI as Your Co-Builder

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This book shares methods and honest expectations, not promises. No book, tool, or AI can guarantee income; results depend on your effort, consistency, and a little luck. Nothing here is financial, legal, or tax advice - for those, talk to a professional in your country. Portions of this book's text and artwork were created with the assistance of AI tools, directed and edited by the author.

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CHAPTER 1

Why Digital Products (and Why Now)

Here is the most important sentence in this book: a digital product is work you do once that can be sold an unlimited number of times, to anyone on Earth, with delivery handled by a machine while you sleep. That single idea - make once, sell forever - is the engine behind every honest 'passive income' story you have ever heard.

A digital product is any file someone will pay to download or use: a budget spreadsheet, a printable planner, a browser game, a music track, an ebook, a set of icons, a Notion template, a knitting pattern. Unlike physical products, there is no inventory, no shipping, no factory, and no marginal cost. Selling one copy costs you the same as selling ten thousand: nothing.

Why this beats the other side hustles

Most side hustles trade time for money: driving, delivering, freelancing. The hours you work are the ceiling of what you earn, and the moment you stop, the money stops. Digital products break that link. The work happens up front; the selling happens forever after. A spreadsheet you finish this weekend can produce its hundredth sale two years from now while you are on holiday.

The catch - and this book will always give you the catch - is that the income curve is backwards compared to a job. A job pays from day one and never grows much. A digital product pays almost nothing at first and compounds: more products, more reviews, more search

rankings, more sales. Most people quit in the flat early weeks. The sellers who win are simply the ones still publishing in month six.

What changed: the AI part

Five years ago, building a digital product required either skills (design, programming, music production, illustration) or money to hire them. That wall has fallen. Modern AI tools can write working code, draw consistent illustrations, compose original music, design covers, and draft product descriptions. You still steer: you pick the product, judge the quality, and do the selling. But the making - the part that used to stop beginners - is no longer the barrier.

Think of AI as a co-builder: a tireless junior partner with every technical skill and zero opinions about what is worth building. Your job in this partnership is taste, direction, and follow-through. That is exactly what the rest of this book teaches.

The honest math

Set expectations now, so nothing later surprises you. A realistic first year for a consistent beginner looks like this: months one and two, a handful of sales as your first listings go live; months three to six, a growing trickle as marketplaces begin ranking your products - often somewhere between fifty and a few hundred dollars a month; months six to twelve, real momentum if you have kept shipping - established template and printable shops commonly reach five hundred to two thousand dollars a month. Some do far better. Many do worse, almost always because they stopped at two products instead of twenty.

One more piece of honesty: 'passive' describes the delivery, not the whole business. Payments, downloads, and hosting run themselves. Marketing does not - expect a few hours a week, forever, tapering as

your catalog compounds. If someone sells you 'fully passive from day one,' they are selling you something.

CHAPTER 2

Meet Your Co-Builder: What AI Can and Cannot Do

Before you build anything, you need an accurate picture of your partner. Overestimating AI wastes your money; underestimating it wastes your opportunity.

What AI does brilliantly

- Writing working software: complete browser games, spreadsheet formulas, website code, automation scripts - reviewed and corrected through conversation.
- Producing consistent flat-style artwork: covers, icons, illustrations for books and listings, all in a matching style you define once.
- Composing original instrumental music: theme songs, ambient loops, and sound effects that are legally yours to sell.
- Drafting the words around a product: descriptions, store pages, social posts, email sequences - faster than any human copywriter, and editable in seconds.
- Being infinitely patient: it will revise the same cover nineteen times without sighing.

What AI cannot do

- It cannot know what people want to buy. Market judgment - watching what sells on Etsy, what ranks on itch.io, what parents

search on Amazon - is your job.

- It cannot create real human singing or Hollywood-grade art. Synthesized music and flat illustration are genuinely sellable; pretending they are something else is not.
- It cannot create accounts, click 'publish,' or accept payments for you. Every platform requires a human owner - you - and that is a feature: it means you own everything.
- It cannot make a bad idea good. AI polish on a product nobody wants produces a beautiful product nobody wants.

The three rules of working with AI

Rule one: you are the editor-in-chief. Never publish anything you have not personally read, played, listened to, or opened. Your name is on it; the AI's is not.

Rule two: disclose honestly where platforms ask. Amazon KDP, some stock marketplaces, and some app stores ask whether AI was involved. Answer truthfully - AI-assisted work is broadly accepted; lying about it is what gets accounts closed.

Rule three: own your rights. Use AI tools whose terms give you commercial rights to the output, keep your source files, and never build on another company's characters or brand - a 'Pokemon-style' game with original creatures is a business; a game with actual Pokemon in it is a takedown letter.

CHAPTER 3

Choosing Your First Product

The biggest beginner mistake is not choosing badly - it is choosing forever. People spend months deciding instead of days building. This chapter gives you a decision framework you can run in one evening.

The three questions

Ask of any product idea: One - does it already sell? You want proof, not novelty. Search Etsy, Gumroad, itch.io, or Amazon for it; if established sellers with hundreds of reviews exist, that is good news - it means demand exists. You are not looking for an empty market; empty markets are usually empty for a reason. Two - can you plus AI actually make it well? Be honest about the quality bar in that niche. Three - is it evergreen? A product tied to one moment (an event, a fad) stops selling; a budget planner sells every January forever.

The beginner's ladder

Products differ wildly in effort. Climb this ladder in order:

- Rung one - printables and templates: budget spreadsheets, invoice kits, planners, checklists. Days to make, proven demand, sell on Etsy and Gumroad. This is the fastest first dollar in the digital world.
- Rung two - low-content and illustrated books: children's picture books, activity books, journals - published free on Amazon KDP, printed on demand.

- Rung three - music and audio: game asset packs, ambient tracks, soundtrack albums on Bandcamp and itch.io.
- Rung four - games and software: browser games, tools, plugins. Highest effort, highest ceilings, and the best free-demo marketing of any product type.

Niche beats general

'Budget spreadsheet' competes with ten thousand listings. 'Wedding budget spreadsheet for couples paying their own way' competes with dozens - and the buyer searching that phrase is far more ready to pay. Every product in this book gets stronger when you aim it at a specific person with a specific problem. Make the general version if you must, then spin out three niched versions; the niches usually outsell the original.

Do this tonight

Pick one rung-one product you could finish within a week. Write one sentence: 'A [product] for [specific person] who wants [specific outcome].' That sentence is your brief for the next chapter - and for your AI co-builder. Done beats perfect; your first product's real job is to teach you the whole pipeline.

CHAPTER 4

Templates and Printables: The Fastest First Dollar

Spreadsheets and printables are the beginner's goldmine: high demand, fast production, and buyers who search with their wallets already open. Someone typing 'monthly budget template' into Etsy is not browsing - they are buying.

What actually sells

The perennial winners: budget and savings trackers, invoice kits for freelancers, planners (daily, meal, wedding, fitness), habit trackers, small-business bookkeeping sheets, and checklist packs. Notice these are all boring. Boring is wonderful. Boring means constant demand and a buyer who wants function, not art.

The quality bar that earns five stars

Ask your AI co-builder for these specifically, because they separate a \$9 template from a refund: an instructions tab that assumes zero spreadsheet knowledge; input cells visually marked (a fill color) so buyers know exactly where to type; every calculation automatic - a buyer should never edit a formula; one realistic example row showing the expected format; currency-neutral design so it sells in every country; and compatibility with both Excel and Google Sheets, stated plainly in the listing.

Packaging and pricing

Deliver a zip containing the file plus a short license text (personal use, no resale). Price singles at seven to fifteen dollars - beginners always underprice; a template that saves someone an hour a month is not a two-dollar product. Then bundle: three related templates at a discount routinely outsells the pieces, because it turns a purchase into a decision already made.

Where to sell

Start on Etsy - it has the search traffic - with all thirteen tags filled, keyword-rich titles, and five to eight listing images (clean screenshots with one benefit caption each; make them from the actual product). Add Gumroad as your no-fee-until-sale second channel and link it from a simple storefront site. Chapter eight builds that storefront for zero dollars.

The one-week plan

Day one: pick the niche sentence from chapter three. Days two and three: build with your AI co-builder and test every cell yourself. Day four: license file, zip, listing images. Day five: Etsy and Gumroad listings live. Days six and seven: first Pinterest pins (chapter nine). Then - and this is the entire secret - start template number two.

CHAPTER 5

Games Without a Studio

Selling a game used to require a studio. Today a browser game built with AI assistance can be genuinely fun, run on every phone and laptop, and sell worldwide from itch.io - the friendliest marketplace on the internet for indie creators.

Why browser games are the beginner's format

No downloads, no installs, no app-store approvals, no thirty-percent platform tax. A buyer clicks your link and is playing in three seconds - which makes every social media post a live demo of your product. The technology (HTML5 and WebGL) runs on effectively every device made in the last decade.

The demo funnel

The proven model: a free demo anyone can play in the browser, and a paid full version. The demo is your marketing; nothing converts like ten seconds of actual fun. Structure it honestly - a real slice of the game, with the full version offering meaningfully more (more levels, more creatures, more buildings), not a crippled tease.

What kind of game can AI build with you?

Cozy genres are the sweet spot: creature collecting, park and farm builders, puzzle games, idle games. They are achievable at high quality without a team, and their audiences actively prefer charming-simple over photorealistic. One absolute rule: original everything. Original creatures, names, art, and music. 'Inspired by' a

genre is how every game is born; copying characters or names is how accounts die.

Selling on itch.io

Create the project as HTML, upload a zip with your game's index file at the root, mark the demo as browser-playable, price the full version five to ten dollars, and fill every field: cover image, four screenshots, trailer if you have one, and every relevant tag ('cozy', 'creature-collector', 'browser'). itch takes a cut you choose (ten percent by default), pays worldwide, and its community genuinely browses for new games.

Beyond the browser

Skip the app stores at first - Apple charges ninety-nine dollars a year plus thirty percent and requires review; that math only works after your game is proven. Instead, make your web game installable (a 'PWA' - your AI knows what that means): players add it to their phone's home screen like a real app, with an icon and offline play, for free. Ship first on the open web; graduate to app stores when revenue says so.

CHAPTER 6

Selling Sounds: Music and Audio

Music is the most misunderstood digital product. Everyone imagines Spotify riches; the real money for independent instrumental music is somewhere else entirely: selling directly to people and to other creators.

The three honest markets

- Direct to listeners on Bandcamp: name-your-price albums where fans keep roughly eighty-five percent flowing to you. Bandcamp buyers famously pay above minimums.
- Asset packs for game developers on itch.io: royalty-free music packs, sold with a license letting buyers use tracks in their own projects. Boring-sounding, reliably bought.
- Streaming (Spotify, Apple Music) through a distributor such as DistroKid or RouteNote: treat this as a business card, not income - streaming pays a few dollars per thousand plays. It exists so your music is findable, embeddable, and credible.

What AI-made music is honestly worth selling

Synthesized instrumental music - ambient, chiptune, cozy game soundtracks, lo-fi - is a real, accepted category with real buyers. What code cannot produce is convincing human singing; do not try to fake it. If you want a vocal track, do what studios do: have AI compose the song and write the lyrics, then hire a singer online for

twenty-five to sixty dollars to record over it. You own the result.

Packaging that sells

Sell WAV (lossless master) plus MP3 together; creators want the WAV, listeners want the MP3. Include a one-page license: buyers may use tracks in their own projects, commercial included, no attribution required; they may not resell the audio itself. Three to five tracks with consistent mood beats one orphan track - packs signal professionalism.

The compounding trick

If you also make games or books, your soundtrack is double-dipped: it ships inside the game, sells separately as an album, and - quietly most valuable - becomes the copyright-safe audio for every promotional video you will ever post. Musicians pay lawyers for that privilege; you will own it outright.

CHAPTER 7

Publishing on Amazon KDP

Kindle Direct Publishing is the single most powerful storefront a beginner can access: free to use, and it puts your book - printed on demand, shipped by Amazon - in front of the largest buying audience on Earth. You upload files; Amazon prints, ships, handles returns, and deposits royalties.

What beginners can realistically publish

- Illustrated children's books: AI-assisted flat illustration plus a warm story. Bedtime, counting, and ABC books are evergreen.
- Activity and puzzle books: word searches, mazes, coloring pages - generatable at scale, steady sellers.
- Journals and planners: your chapter-four templates reborn as paper.
- Practical nonfiction: teach one specific thing to one specific reader, plainly.

The mechanics, demystified

Sign up at kdp.amazon.com and complete the tax interview (it is a form, not an exam). For a paperback you upload two PDFs: the manuscript at your chosen trim size (children's books: 8.5 by 8.5 inches square; nonfiction: 6 by 9), and a cover sized to Amazon's calculator - it depends on page count because of the spine. Price using Amazon's royalty preview: color children's books usually land at ten to fourteen dollars, black-and-white nonfiction at eight to

fifteen, ebooks at three to seven with seventy percent royalty in the middle band.

The two things that decide whether it sells

First, the cover. Buyers judge in a thumbnail at eighty pixels wide. Big title, high contrast, one clear image. Second, keywords and categories: KDP gives you seven keyword slots - fill them with phrases parents or readers actually type ('bedtime story about animals', 'budget planner book'), and choose the two most specific categories allowed. Amazon is a search engine; treat your listing like a search result.

Disclosure and rights

KDP asks whether AI was used in creating text or images. Answer honestly - AI-assisted books are permitted with disclosure. Keep your source files as proof of your process. And the same law of the land as always: original characters, original words, original art.

The series effect

One book rarely changes anything. Five related books change everything - they share an audience, appear in each other's 'customers also bought', and compound reviews. Publish book one, start book two the same week. In children's books this is trivially natural: bedtime book, counting book, ABC book, seasons book, all with the same beloved characters.

CHAPTER 8

Your Free Storefront and Brand

Marketplaces bring traffic; a storefront of your own brings ownership. The goal is a simple, fast website that lists everything you sell, links to each marketplace, and costs exactly zero dollars.

The zero-dollar stack

A static website - plain HTML, no databases - hosted free on GitHub Pages (or Netlify or Cloudflare Pages). Ask your AI co-builder for a one-page store: product cards, prices, buy buttons, a FAQ, mobile-friendly. Payments never touch your site; every buy button links out to Gumroad, itch.io, Bandcamp, or Amazon, which handle cards, taxes, and delivery. You get a professional storefront with no monthly fee, no security burden, and no code to maintain by hand.

One brand, many shelves

Give everything one name and one look. A buyer of your budget planner should recognize your game's store page; a fan of your game should recognize your book's cover. Shared characters, shared colors, shared tone. This is how one-person shops look bigger than they are - and why every new product launches warmer than the last: cross-promotion inside your own catalog is the only advertising that is free forever.

The connective tissue

Wire every property to the others. Store links to all marketplaces. Each marketplace description links back to the store. The book's last page mentions the game; the game's credits mention the soundtrack; the soundtrack's album notes mention the book. Add a free email signup (a free mini-product in exchange for an address) the moment you have two products - your email list is the only audience no platform can take away from you.

A custom domain: the one worthwhile ten dollars

Everything above is free. If you spend money on one thing, spend ten dollars a year on a domain name. 'yourbrand.com' converts meaningfully better than a free subdomain because it looks like a business - which, by that point, it is.

CHAPTER 9

Marketing That Compounds

Products do not sell themselves; systems sell products. The good news: as a digital seller you need exactly one system, run consistently. The theme of this chapter is choosing marketing that compounds - work that keeps paying after you stop - over marketing that evaporates.

The hierarchy, in order of priority

- Marketplace SEO (Etsy, Amazon, itch searches): the buyer is already searching with intent. Keyword-rich titles, every tag filled, strong images. This is the highest-value hour you will spend.
- Pinterest: not social media - a visual search engine where a good pin drives traffic for years. Three to five pins per product, posted steadily. Printables and planners live here.
- Short-form video (TikTok, Reels, Shorts): the discovery jackpot. A fifteen-second screen recording - 'watch this spreadsheet build a budget', 'I made a game where you build a creature park' - can outperform months of everything else. Post the process, not an ad.
- Communities (Reddit and Discord): powerful and easily misused. Share free value - the demo, a free printable - in relevant communities, sparingly, as a human being. Communities smell self-promotion instantly; generosity is the only entry fee.

The weekly rhythm

Sustainable beats heroic. A workable weekly hour-count for a person with a job: two hours making or improving a product, one hour of pins and one short video, thirty minutes replying and community reading. That modest rhythm, held for six months, beats any two-week sprint ever attempted.

Free is a strategy

Every free thing you release - the game demo, a one-page planner, a sample track - is a salesperson working around the clock. Free items rank in marketplace searches, get shared in ways paid products never are, and each one carries a link back to the paid catalog. When in doubt, cut a small free slice off a paid product and set it loose.

What to measure

Weekly, note three numbers per product: views, sales, conversion. High views and no sales means the listing (price, images, description) is broken. No views means the keywords are. Fix the one that is broken, not the one that is not. And measure monthly, not daily - daily numbers in a young shop are noise that will only sadden you.

CHAPTER 10

The Owner's Manual: Money, Rules, and the Long Game

This final chapter is the boring one that keeps the money you make. Read it twice.

Pricing without fear

Beginners underprice out of impostor feeling, and low prices signal low quality to buyers - a two-dollar planner reads as worthless; a twelve-dollar one reads as serious. Price on the value of the outcome (the hours saved, the delight delivered), test upward, and remember bundles: your catalog's best price is the one that sells three things at once.

Licenses: the words that protect you

Every product ships with a short plain-language license. For consumer products: personal use, no redistribution or resale. For creative assets (music, templates for reuse): buyers may use them inside their own projects, commercial included, but may not resell the asset itself. Two paragraphs, written once by your AI co-builder, reused forever.

Taxes and paperwork, gently

Marketplaces handle sales tax and VAT on digital goods in most places - one of the great hidden gifts of selling through them. Your income, however, is still income: keep a simple monthly record of

revenue per platform, expect end-of-year tax forms from each, and when the money becomes real, spend one hour with a local accountant. One hour, once - it answers everything specific to your country.

Scams and traps

The moment you start selling online, predators notice. The reliable rules: nobody legitimate emails asking you to pay a fee to 'unlock' earnings; platforms never ask for your password by message; 'guaranteed passive income' courses costing hundreds of dollars teach what free documentation teaches; and any 'buyer' who wants to move the conversation off-platform to pay you is not a buyer.

When something works, do it again

The endgame is a portfolio, not a product: many small streams, each modest, none load-bearing. The practical loop is beautifully dull - ship, measure, keep what works, make more like it. A template that sells becomes a family of six. A game that sells gets a sequel and a soundtrack. A book that sells becomes a series. Every repeat is faster than the original, because you and your co-builder have done it before.

The last honest word

Most people who read a book like this build nothing. Not because the methods fail - because the first flat weeks convince them it is not working, and they stop exactly where the curve begins to bend. You now know the curve is flat at the start for everyone. Ship the small thing this week. Then ship the next one. The compounding takes care of the rest.

Before You Go

Your 30-day starting plan: Week one - build and launch one template on Etsy and Gumroad. Week two - set up your free storefront and Pinterest, first pins live. Week three - start product two (a bundle-mate for product one) and post your first short video. Week four - publish product two, review your three numbers, and choose the next rung of the ladder. Twelve months from now, the version of you with twenty products will be very glad you started with one.